

Alongside Brain, the 80's saw other major viruses such as "Vienna" and "Cascade". This twosome created something of an epidemic between 1987-89. PC users still remember those days: letters would drop from displays making people draw the obvious conclusion that there was something wrong with their monitors. It wasn't the best of times if your job description involved servicing monitors. But cascading letters weren't the only thing infected computers would display. Some would start playing the "Yankee Doodle" number... weird times, for sure.

With viruses suddenly and irritatingly popping up from the most unlikely of sources, the time was now for saviours. People were desperate for solutions. And so there appeared antidotes. Like the malady, the first cure is hard to pinpoint. Which was the first antivirus, is difficult to identify but it wasn't until 1990 that a visible number of solutions were introduced. And when it rained, it poured. Antivirus solutions were aplenty, including software from IBM, McAfee, Digital Dispatch and Iris. Only a handful of them have survived to this day and even fewer grew from little more than a garage project to major players in the computer security market. Antivirus software had arrived and not a moment too soon.

Come 1990 and viruses started displaying a variety of characteristics. These included Polymorphism—encrypted viruses where the decryption routine code was variable, Armoring—to prevent antivirus researchers from disassembling a virus and Multipartite—able to infect both programs and boot sectors.

The first polymorphic virus was called "Chameleon". By April 1991, everyone was taking shots of "Tequila"—a virus which was Stealth, Polymorphic and Multipartite; a very real and problematic threat. Suddenly, viruses became a lot more threatening.

After Tequila, the idea of a self-encrypting, polymorphic virus gained popularity in the wrong circles and spawned a completely unique software—a polymorphic code generator. Creating slippery viruses was now much simpler.